Mehrdad Pourghasem

PhD Candidate in Economics, Pennsylvania State University

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Research Interests

Industrial Organization, Health Economics, and Applied Microeconomics

Education

PhD in Economics, Pennsylvania State University, USA 2022–2028 (expected)
Fields: Industrial Organization, Health Economics
Dissertation: *Who Chooses Your Hospital? Inherited Demand and the Measurement of Hospital Competition*
Advisors: Conor Ryan and Paul Grieco; Committee: Bradley Setzler, David Vanness

MSc in Economics, Sharif University of Technology, Iran 2019–2022
Thesis: *Road Infrastructure and Agricultural Outcomes*; ranked 1st in cumulative GPA in cohort

BSc in Industrial Engineering, Sharif University of Technology, Iran 2014–2019

Research

Who Chooses Your Hospital? Inherited Demand and the Measurement of Hospital Competition. *Job Market Paper*

- Shows that elective surgical demand is routed by referral menus belonging to primary care organizations rather than chosen by patients, using claims covering 8.5 million commercially insured Californians.
- Documents menu persistence across three margins: menus barely move when an organization's physicians are replaced, transfer with physicians who change employer, and reallocate when organizations close.
- Estimates a consideration-set demand model that places 2.4 of 48 available hospitals on the effective menu; replaying observed organization closures, the standard merger-review model recovers 41% of measured within-system diversion against 88% for the menu model—a bias that clears mergers that should be flagged.

Heterogeneous Willingness-to-Pay for Electric Vehicles. *3rd Year Paper*

- Merges U.S. market-level auto sales data (Ward's) with household-level purchase data (CEX) and detailed vehicle attributes.
- Estimates random-coefficients logit demand (BLP) with demographic interactions and micro-moments to recover heterogeneous willingness-to-pay.
- Documents substantial heterogeneity: higher EV valuations among urban and college-educated households, and stronger baseline EV disutility among rural, low-income, and non-college-educated households.

Road Infrastructure & Agricultural Outcomes. *MSc Thesis*

- Constructs a county-level panel for Iran linking village road access to farmland rental rates (2006 and 2011).
- Uses fixed-effects estimation and ArcGIS spatial analysis to evaluate impacts on local land values and agricultural outcomes.

Teaching Experience

Instructor, Pennsylvania State University Summer 2025
Introduction to Macroeconomic Analysis and Policy; enrollment: 38 students.

Teaching Assistant, Pennsylvania State University Fall 2022–Present
Courses: International Finance, Advanced International Trade.

Teaching Assistant, Sharif University of Technology Fall 2017–Fall 2021
Courses: Energy Economics, Game Theory, Principles of Economics, System Dynamics.

Professional Experience

Research Analyst Oct 2019–Dec 2020
Morvarid Petrochemical Company, Tehran, Iran

- Led a four-member team to translate broad strategic questions into a research plan with clear milestones in collaboration

with the CEO.
- Built a dynamic forecasting model linking macroeconomic indicators to output and profitability.
- Synthesized quantitative and qualitative findings into executive presentations with actionable operational and risk recommendations.

Research Analyst Oct 2017–Dec 2018
Iranian Water Policy Research Institute, Tehran, Iran
- Evaluated regional water-market design alternatives using field interviews and international case-study evidence.
- Quantified impacts of alternative water allocation policies using statistical models.
- Presented findings to 100+ stakeholders at a multi-day Chamber of Commerce forum.

Research Analyst Jul 2017–Sep 2017
Urmia Lake Restoration Commission, Tehran, Iran
- Gathered and documented business requirements for three startup initiatives and translated needs into technical specifications.

Business Analyst Jul 2016–Jul 2017
Smartup Ventures, Tehran, Iran
- Conducted market research and feasibility analyses for three startup ventures.
- Promoted to CEO Assistant within six months; coordinated cross-functional teams for rebranding and website launch.

Technical Skills

Programming and Analysis: Python (pandas, NumPy, PyBLP), R, Stata, SQL, LaTeX
Economics and Econometrics: Structural estimation (consideration-set and BLP demand, Nash-in-Nash bargaining, merger simulation, diversion ratios); causal inference (difference-in-differences, IV, event study); panel data; large administrative claims data
Data and Visualization: ArcGIS, Tableau, Power BI
Languages: English, Persian

Honors and Awards

- Ranked 1st in Cumulative GPA among Economics (Energy Economics) students, Sharif University of Technology, 2019–2021
- Top 0.5% among 10,000+ participants in the Nationwide University Entrance Exam for MSc in Economics, 2019
- Top 0.5% among 40,000+ participants in the Mathematics and Physics Nationwide University Entrance Exam (Konkur)

Extracurricular Activities

Sharif University of Technology
- Executive Director, Student Guild Council
- Member, Swimming Team

References

Conor Ryan (Advisor)
Assistant Professor of Economics
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Paul Grieco (Advisor)
Professor of Economics
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Bradley Setzler (Committee)
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